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CATALYSING HERITAGE: Why the past is still the future of India's tourism growth story

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REVIVING RICH HISTORIES

Architect Abha Narain Lambah on the unexplored tourist potential of India's cultural sites and what the country needs to race ahead of rivals in the industry

Architect Abha Narain Lambah didn't mince words in laying out the harsh realities of India's tourism industry, emphasising how India's architectural and cultural heritage remains "greatly untapped", with stakeholders unaware of its enormous potential.

Two facts underscoring the dismal situation: Paris's Louvre attracts almost as many visitors, annually, as the total number of foreign tourists visiting India the same period; India only has 3,900 nationally protected monuments, significantly less than United Kingdom, which is smaller than Uttar Pradesh but has a lakh such sites.

If India wants to see tourism contribute more to its economy, says Lambah, acquiring UNESCO tags is the way to go. China, she notes, is far more active than any nation in preparing dossiers for its heritage. Lambah's eponymous firm has made many successful dossiers, including for Rabindranath Tagore's Shantiniketan and Lucknow as a creative city for gastronomy. Sarnath is next.

TAKEAWAYS

- **The tourism department needs to work in sync with urban development, culture, archaeology, heritage and city planning departments to create a more wholesome experience for travellers**
- Getting a UNESCO tag is the ideal way for cities and countries to project themselves, with serial nominations being an effective strategy. Mumbai's Victoria and art deco precinct with 83 buildings is an example
- **The quality of tourists as well as their spending and influence on local economy is more important than the mere footfall**
- Heritage and cultural conservation should be seen as an enabler of community

—with ***Suhani Singh***



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